

DCSA INNOVATION GATEWAY

DEFENSE COUNTERINTELLIGENCE AND SECURITY AGENCY





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1. OVERVIEW

1.1. GENERAL INFORMATION

Solicitation Title: DCSA INNOVATION GATEWAY

Solicitation Number: HS0021-26-CSO-DCSA

Publication Date: 23 June 2026 – 22 June 2031

NAICS Code: 541512 - Computer Systems Design Services

Agency Contacts: See Innovation Call for specific points of contact.

1.2. SHORT DESCRIPTION

The DCSA Innovation Gateway is a competitive solicitation that will result in the award of prototype projects. It is our commercially-focused front door for innovators. Our goal is simple: to partner with creative companies to solve our most critical mission challenges.

1.3. INNOVATION GATEWAY PROCESS

The Innovation Gateway is a general announcement of DCSA's general areas of interest (see Sections 2 – DCSA Technical Priorities), including criteria for selecting Solution Concept Papers and soliciting the participation of all proposers capable of satisfying the Government's needs.

Proposal requests will be issued via 'Innovation Calls' that are published separately under the DCSA Innovation Gateway at various times during the open period of this solicitation.

Innovation Calls will be published via Sam.gov referencing the DCSA Innovation Gateway.

1.4. AWARD TYPES

Other Transaction Agreements (OTA) for prototypes IAW 10 U.S.C. 4022

The term "prototype project" includes a project that addresses-

- (A) a proof of concept, model, or process, including a business process;
- (B) reverse engineering to address obsolescence;
- (C) a pilot or novel application of commercial technologies for defense purposes;
- (D) agile development activity;
- (E) the creation, design, development, or demonstration of operational utility; or
- (F) any combination of subparagraphs (A) through (E).



2. DCSA TECHNICAL PRIORITIES

2.1. DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION ENABLEMENT

DCSA seeks prototype efforts that accelerate **agency-wide digital transformation** by improving how digital capabilities are designed, delivered, governed, and sustained. Priority is on solutions that are **reusable across multiple mission and business areas**, reduce delivery timelines, improve user experience, and increase operational resilience and security.

Digital Service Delivery Acceleration: Prototypes that shorten time-to-capability through repeatable delivery patterns (e.g., standardized environments, automated pipelines, release orchestration, and operational readiness practices) that can be adopted across diverse systems.

Cloud and Infrastructure Modernization as an Enabler: Solutions that simplify adoption and operation of modern hosting approaches through automation, resilience, performance optimization, and cost transparency—focused on enterprise applicability rather than single-system optimization.

Modular Architecture and Incremental Modernization: Prototypes that promote modular, replaceable components aligned with MOSA principles, enabling stepwise modernization, reduced vendor lock-in, and easier integration with existing systems.

Operational Excellence and Continuous Compliance: Efforts that build in observability, configuration management, incident readiness, and continuous compliance approaches so modernized capabilities can operate securely and reliably at scale.

2.2. DATA INTEGRATION AND ADVANCED ANALYTICS

Data-Driven Decision Making: Enhancing data understanding, delivery, and management to enable faster, more accurate risk determinations in personnel and industrial security.

AI and Machine Learning: Implementing a variety of Artificial Intelligence (AI) capabilities to analyze large volumes of data, identify anomalies, and calculate potential risks while keeping human judgment at the center of trust decisions.

Automated Data Ingestion: Developing tools to automatically ingest data, improving the speed and quality of background investigations.

2.3. CYBER AND INDUSTRIAL SECURITY

Securing the Defense Industrial Base: Protecting cleared facilities and IT systems from cyber-attacks, foreign insider threats, and vulnerabilities.

Behavioral Threat Analysis Capability (BTAC): Enhancing capabilities to detect insider threats through advanced behavioral monitoring.

Zero Trust Architecture: Strengthening cyber posture through modern, secure IT solutions that protect sensitive national security information.

2.4. DIGITAL WORKFORCE AND GOVERNANCE

Digital Skills Training: Empowering a skilled digital workforce, including expanding AI experience and cybersecurity awareness.

IT Governance: Establishing enterprise-wide IT, data, and cybersecurity governance to ensure compliance and efficiency.



3. ELIGIBILITY

3.1. OTA ELIGIBILITY

Consistent with 10 U.S.C. § 4022, the awardee for a prototype OT must meet at least one of the following requirements:

- (A) There is at least one nontraditional defense contractor or nonprofit research institution participating to a significant extent in the prototype project.

Definition: A nontraditional defense contractor is an entity that is not currently performing, and has not for at least one year prior to the issuance of this solicitation, performed any contract or subcontract for the Department of Defense that is subject to full coverage under the Cost Accounting Standards (CAS).
- (B) All significant participants in the transaction other than the Federal Government are small businesses [including small businesses participating in a program described under section 9 of the Small Business Act (15 U.S.C. § 638)] or nontraditional defense contractors.
- (C) At least one third of the total cost of the prototype project is to be paid out of funds provided by sources other than the Federal Government.

3.2. SECURITY REQUIREMENTS & FOREIGN PARTICIPATION

Each Innovation Call will specify whether non-U.S. organizations and/or individuals may participate and any specific controls or security regulations that apply. If allowable under the Innovation Call, any and all forms of foreign participation must be clearly and fully disclosed within the proposal. For controlled unclassified information (CUI) and classified submissions, this includes disclosing and mitigating any Foreign Ownership Control and Influence (FOCI) issues prior to transmitting the submission to DCSA. Additional information on FOCI can be found at <https://www.dcsa.mil/mc/isd/foci/>.

3.3. COST SHARING/MATCHING

Cost sharing is not required; however, it will be carefully considered where there is an applicable statutory condition relating to the selected funding instrument (e.g., OTs under the authority of 10 U.S.C. § 4022).

OTs for prototypes require cost sharing unless at least one nontraditional defense contractor is significantly involved, or all significant participants in the transaction are small businesses or nontraditional defense contractors. If the proposing team is not composed of the required entities listed above, it is required to provide at least one-third (1/3) cost share from their own funds, unless a case can be made for a waiver. Waivers are not common and will require significant justification.

Notwithstanding these requirements, cost sharing is encouraged where there is a reasonable probability of a potential commercial application related to the proposed effort. Any cost sharing arrangement should be noted in the Solution Concept Paper and Full Project Proposal.



4. INNOVATION CALL

DCSA will publish specific requirements through the release of an 'Innovation Call'. Innovation Calls will be published on SAM.gov and will reference this solicitation, the DCSA Innovation Gateway.

The Government will only accept proposals in response to Innovation Calls. **Unsolicited proposals that are not in response to an Innovation Call will not be reviewed by the Government.**

Innovation Calls will consist of the following phases:

- Phase 1: Solution Concept Paper
- Phase 2: Invitation-Only Evaluation (optional)
- Phase 3: Negotiation & Award

4.1. PHASE 1: SOLUTION CONCEPT PAPER

4.1.1. DESCRIPTION

Interested vendors are invited to submit a 6-page 'Solution Concept Paper' in response to an Innovation Call. The Government will review all submitted Solution Concept Papers. Vendors should be aware that this initial review may serve as the sole and entire evaluation.

Following this review, the Government reserves the right to:

- Select the most promising vendor(s) and proceed directly to Phase 3 (Negotiation & Award).
- Invite a limited number of selected vendors to participate in Phase 2.
- Determine that no submissions are suitable and make no selections.

4.1.2. SUBMISSION

GENERAL INFORMATION

Solution Concept Papers shall be submitted electronically, via email, to the email specified in the Innovation Call.

E-mail Subject Line: "DCSA – Innovation Call [insert #] - Concept Paper [insert Company Name]".

Please see Innovation Call for specific timelines for Solution Concept Paper submission.

All submissions will be acknowledged with an email confirmation within 24 hours of receipt. If a confirmation email is not received within 48 hours, please follow up to ensure delivery. DCSA is not responsible for email system malfunctions or undeliverable email.

FORMAT

Notwithstanding specific format instructions provided in the Innovation Calls, concept papers shall be submitted in accordance with this announcement.

The Solution Concept Paper is not a full proposal. Vendors shall not include detailed project plans, formal quotes, or team résumés. Instead, vendors shall focus exclusively on the quality of their proposed concept.

Proposers shall use the Solution Concept Paper Template (Attachment 1).



Proposers are prohibited from altering any of the settings in this template (i.e. font-type, font size, line spacing, margins). Graphics/illustrations are allowed and are not subject to the format restrictions. Tables are allowed but are subject to format restrictions. Proposers shall replace/delete all grey instructions within the template after completion. **Any Solution Concept Paper that does not utilize the required template (Attachment 1) will not be considered for review.**

4.1.3. EVALUATION

The Government will review Solution Concept Papers against the following criteria:

1. **Concept Viability:** Is the idea innovative, technically sound, and compelling? Are the proposed data rights and licensing viable for long-term integration?
2. **Mission Alignment:** Does the vendor deeply understand the problem and its operational impact?
3. **Affordability:** Is the ROM cost within an acceptable range for a prototype effort?

Solution Concept papers will be evaluated on the basis of their own merit of the proposed concept in addressing the Innovation Call and the factors above, not against other Solution Concept Papers submitted in response to the same Innovation Call.

DCSA will notify vendors of their Solution Concept Paper evaluation results (e.g. Phase 2, if applicable). Please note that debriefs or feedback regarding Phase 1 submissions will not be provided.

4.2. PHASE 2: FULL PROJECT PROPOSAL

Selected vendors may receive an official invitation to participate in a second phase of evaluation.

The specific nature of this phase will be defined in the invitation but could consist of a request for

- Full Project Proposal
- Technical Demonstration
- Oral Presentation.

This phase is optional and will only be conducted if the Government deems it necessary.

4.3. PHASE 3: NEGOTIATION & AWARD

Vendors selected for award (from either Phase 1 or Phase 2) will proceed to this phase. The process includes collaborative project development, administrative compliance checks, and final award execution.

4.3.1. COLLABORATIVE NEGOTIATION

The primary goal of this phase is to collaboratively establish the framework for the prototype project. Key activities include:

- Refining the technical approach;
- Developing a detailed Statement of Work (SOW);
- Establishing well-defined milestones and associated deliverables;
- Establishing a fair and reasonable price; and
- Agreeing upon the mutual terms and conditions for the award.



4.3.2. VENDOR ELIGIBILITY & ADMINISTRATIVE REQUIREMENTS

To be eligible for an award, a vendor must meet the following administrative requirements prior to the execution of an Other Transaction Agreement (OTA):

- **OTA Statutory Eligibility:** The award must comply with the requirements of 10 U.S.C. § 4022 as described in section 3.1.
- **Company Security Clearance:** The vendor must possess any required facility or personnel security clearances if required within an Innovation Call.
- **Responsibility Determination:** The vendor must be determined to be a responsible party by the Agreements Officer.
- **System for Award Management (SAM):** Companies must have an active registration in SAM and possess a Unique Entity Identifier (UEI).
- **Suspension & Debarment:** The vendor must not be suspended or debarred from award by the Federal Government, nor be prohibited by law or Executive Order from receiving an award.
- **Invoicing System:** Companies must register and be active in the prescribed Government invoicing system (e.g., Procurement Integrated Enterprise Environment (PIEE)).
- **Organizational Conflicts of Interest (OCI):** Any potential OCIs must be addressed and mitigated.

4.3.3. GOVERNMENT AUTHORITY & RIGHTS

- **Agreements Officer Authority:** The Agreements Officer will negotiate directly with the vendor on the terms and conditions of the OTA, including payments, and is the sole individual with the authority to enter into, modify, or otherwise execute a binding agreement on behalf of the Government.
- **Government Reservation of Rights:** Receipt of a Request for Proposal or selection for this negotiation phase does not guarantee an award. The Government reserves the right, at any point prior to the execution of an OT agreement, to cancel this solicitation for any reason.

Upon successful completion of all collaborative and administrative activities, and with available funds, the Agreements Officer may execute an award.



5. PROTOTYPE PROJECTS INFORMATION

5.1. ITERATIVE DEVELOPMENT & MODIFICATION

OTAs awarded under the DCSA Innovation Gateway will be awarded with the intent to use an iterative development approach. As such, the Government and the vendor may mutually agree to modify the project's scope, objectives, and technical requirements during performance.

This authority allows for:

- Adapting the prototype based on technical discoveries and results from testing and evaluation.
- Expanding the project's scope to address new or refined operational requirements as they are identified.
- Implementing these changes efficiently within the scope of the existing OT, without the need for a new competitive action.

5.2. SUCCESSFUL PROJECT COMPLETION

A prototype project will be considered "successfully completed" upon a written determination by the appropriate Government official that the project has met at least one of the following criteria:

- Fulfilled the key technical goals as described in the Statement of Work;
- Satisfied the objective success metrics established in the OT agreement; or
- Achieved a favorable or unexpected result that provides significant operational utility and justifies a transition to production.

Partial Completion & Early Transition: The Government may declare a specific aspect or component of a prototype project successfully completed before the conclusion of the entire effort. This allows the Government to transition valuable capabilities into production while other parts of the project are still in development.

The conditions for both full and partial completion will be explicitly defined in the final OT agreement.

5.3. POTENTIAL FOR FOLLOW-ON PRODUCTION OTA

In accordance with 10 U.S.C. §4022(f), a follow-on production contract or transaction may be awarded to the participants of prototype projects without further competition. This opportunity is contingent upon the successful completion of the prototype project to the satisfaction of the Government.

The follow-on production may include, but is not limited to, the procurement of additional units, scaling of the prototype technology, or implementation of the solution.



6. RESTRICTIVE MARKINGS

Records or data subject to restrictions on their use may be included in the concept papers and proposals but shall be clearly marked. The proposer shall clearly identify and mark any proprietary data that is intended to be used by the Government only. The proposer shall also identify any technical data or computer software contained in the Solution Concept Paper and proposal that is being provided with restrictions on its use by the Government. In the absence of such identification, the Government will assume to have unlimited rights to all technical data or computer software contained in the concept paper.

It is the intent of DCSA to treat all Solution Concept Papers and proposals as procurement sensitive information before the award, and to disclose their contents only to Government employees or designated support contractors for the purpose of procurement related activities only. Classified, sensitive, or critical information on technologies should not be included in the concept paper.

Proposers are cautioned that portions of a concept paper may be subject to release under terms of the Freedom of Information Act, 5 U.S.C. § 552, as amended.

7. NON-GOVERNMENT ADVISORS

Non-Government advisors may be used in the evaluation of Solution Concept Papers, Full Project proposals, and during negotiations. Non-Government advisors will have signed non-disclosure agreements (NDAs) with the Government. Submission of an offer under this solicitation will constitute a grant of authority by the submitting vendor to the Government to allow the use of non-Government advisors to participate in evaluations of all phases of the solicitation process.

8. LIST OF ATTACHMENTS

Attachment 1 - Solution Concept Paper Template